

Source-Backed RAG for Accounting Workflows

• CTO

• Accounting Firm

• Enterprise Finance

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THE QUESTION

Should an accounting AI answer from model memory, or from sources it can cite?

THE SHORT ANSWER

Retrieval-augmented generation lets an AI answer from documents instead of memory, but it is only as trustworthy as the rules around retrieval. Govern which sources are eligible, rank by authority and applicability, limit the context, verify citations and make the system stop when nothing relevant is found.

FOUR KEY IDEAS

1 Memory is the wrong place for rules

Accounting requirements change, vary by jurisdiction and carry consequences. A model's memory is frozen, blended and unattributed.

2 Most failures are retrieval failures

Wrong source, stale version, wrong jurisdiction, broken context, diluted context, hollow citations and silent gaps all arise from how retrieval is set up.

3 Authority before similarity

Rank by authority and applicability, filter before you rank, keep rules with their exceptions, and pass fewer, better passages.

4 Test retrieval and answers separately

A single score hides which part failed. Include questions the sources cannot answer, and check that the system stops.

WHO SHOULD READ THE FULL PAPER

CTOs and technical leaders, accounting firm leaders and enterprise finance teams, and the engineers and reviewers who will evaluate retrieval-based AI.

INSIDE THE FULL PAPER

What the full paper covers

#	SECTION	WHAT IT ANSWERS
1	Why accounting cannot run on model memory	A language model's memory is a poor place to keep rules that change, vary by jurisdiction and carry consequences.
2	How ungoverned RAG fails in accounting	Most failures are not the model inventing things. They are retrieval returning the wrong thing, convincingly.
3	Governing the corpus	Retrieval can only be as good as what it is allowed to retrieve.
4	Governing retrieval and ranking	The ranking step decides which passages the model ever sees, so it decides most of what the answer can be.
5	Governing generation and citation	Once passages are chosen, the remaining question is whether the answer stays within them.
6	Evaluating a source-backed system	Retrieval quality and answer quality are different things. Measure them separately.
7	Architecture questions for technical leaders	Ten questions that separate a governed deployment from a demonstration.

QUESTIONS THIS PAPER HELPS YOU ASK

☐	Which sources may be retrieved, and who approved them?
☐	Does ranking weigh authority, applicability and effective date?
☐	What does the system do when nothing relevant is found?
☐	Can each claim be traced to a passage that actually supports it?
☐	Are retrieved passages and versions logged so an answer can be reconstructed?

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